

Lesson 9: Communicating for Success: Getting the Message Across

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Pat believed in communication so much that it is *Definite Dozen Principle #4: Learn to be a Great Communicator*.

As women in the workplace, good communication is key to getting your ideas across, networking with colleagues and communicating with upper leadership. Male OR female, the art of mastering communication is a lifetime goal.

There are several parts to great communication – Pat liked to focus on three in particular: tone, situation, and nonverbal communication. Another area that can be challenging for women in particular is avoiding the use of qualifying or filler words.

Filler words are words like kind of, sort of, really, very, little, pretty that diminish the power of what you're trying to say.

Which sounds more confident:

“I could be wrong, but I sort of think we should pick the first option.”

or simply:

“I would choose the first option.”

Do you see the difference? There were *three* qualifying words in that first statement!

Qualifying phrases are words like “I’m not sure but...” or “If I’m not mistaken...” or “Correct me if I’m wrong, but...” Women are more prone to these words than men in their communication.

Another key component of communication for both genders to master is the art of brevity. Men typically use less words than women, but this is a skill for both genders to take into consideration – the art of communicating succinctly...and powerfully.

How are your voice mails? Are you able to state the message in 30 seconds or less, or do you find yourself getting cut off at the beep? What about text messages and emails? More than 2-3 paragraphs in an email may come across a little differently than intended, if this is your normal habit.

Whether we're talking about body language, active listening or the timing of a message, there is so much to learn here, it would be impossible to cover it all. The point is being open-minded and self-aware of how you're communicating in the workplace – which areas are your strengths, and which areas you can improve on. Ask a colleague for a second opinion if you're not sure!

Now that we know more of what to look for, let's take a closer look.